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Online scams: how to recognise them and what to do

Scammers don't attack the computer: they attack haste and trust. Almost all scams share the same signs, and learning to spot them is the best defence.

Warning signs

- **Urgency**: "within 24 hours", "account blocked", "final notice".
- **Requests for codes**: passwords, PINs, the code you received by text message, card details.
- **Links** in texts, emails or WhatsApp leading to a page where you enter your details.
- **Strange sender or website**: the address isn't the official one, even if the logo looks right.
- **Unusual payments**: top-ups, instant transfers, cryptocurrency, gift cards.
- **Offers too good to be true**: easy money, prizes, products at half price.

The most common scams

- A fake text from the bank or the post office reporting a suspicious login.
- The fake courier: a parcel on hold and a small payment to make.
- A fake bank employee who calls, sometimes from the real number spoofed, and asks you to move your money to a "safe account".
- "Hi Mum, I've changed my number" on WhatsApp, with an urgent request for money.
- Fake investments advertised with famous faces.
- The fake technician who asks you to install a program to control the computer remotely.

The golden rules

- Banks, the post office and the police will never ask you for codes, passwords or to move money.
- If in doubt, hang up and call the official number yourself: the one on the back of your card or on the website, typed by hand.
- Don't install programs because a caller asks you to.
- Turn on notifications for card transactions.
- Before paying in a hurry, talk to someone you trust.

If you've fallen for it

- Block your card or account straight away by calling the bank's official number.
- Change your passwords, starting with your email, and turn on two-step verification.
- If you installed a remote-control program, turn the computer off and have it checked.
- Report it to the police (in Italy, the Polizia Postale, also online at commissariatodips.it).
- Keep texts, emails and receipts: they are evidence.

There's no need to feel ashamed: scams are made by professionals and can catch anyone. Talking about them helps others not to fall for them.

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